and atrocious activities of terrorists in Pakistan. Moreover, all indicators confirm a constant upward trend in religious extremism and radicalisation. The state will have to tackle this menace with all its might, sincerity and seriousness. Otherwise, this menace will cause serious and irreparable damage to every sector of the country.

Taliban- and Al Qaeda-related security concerns have led a lot of academics and experts to explore various avenues and aspects of the subject. Some of these studies have explained the genesis and metamorphism of Taliban from *madrasah* (religious seminary) students to a full-fledged force to reckon with in Afghanistan, while others have focused on Al Qaeda. The studies on Al Qaeda have delved into the mysteries and genesis of this global phenomenon and its metastasis into much localised cells in different countries, drawing identity from a single transnational ideology that made it a mercurial entity. However, researchers and academics have not conducted any serious and comprehensive work on terrorist outfits in Pakistan, especially the TTP, which is the most formidable of all. The impact of the TTP's activities is not only countrywide, but also region-wide and even felt internationally. Despite this worrisome existence and growth of the TTP, there is a huge knowledge gap in understanding this phenomenon.

The study of the Pakistani Taliban is a very fast-moving and contemporary subject with inconclusive published data, mainly relying on news items, articles and interviews. Nevertheless, the literature published in leading journals about terrorism and jihadists in Pakistan and other related issues was also extensively analysed. A number of interviews and surveys were conducted, which gave good insights into the phenomenon that posed critical threats to the stability of Pakistan.

In recent years, ever since it had taken refuge in Afghanistan after its dislocation from Waziristan, the TTP became a graver danger for Pakistan as it organised terrorist attacks through its remnants and recruits in Pakistan with impunity. Its growing proximity with the so-called Islamic State terrorist group became a palpable threat to the region and beyond.